Subject : **77039_1_1 Actors i Règims of Global Governance**

Name of the course : Migration

Name of the professor : Dr.Valeria Bello

Name of the Student : Tristan VEZIO

Title of the Essay : Key insights for a good migration policy system in Morocco : dilemmas and policy recommendations.

Wordcount : 1.554 words

Date of submission : Sunday May the 10th.

IA Disclaimer :

I hereby declare that this assignment was written by me, in my own words, except for texts either quoted directly or paraphrased, which are clearly indicated and acknowledged as such. Full bibliographic details are given in the reference list, which also contains any internet sources including the URL and access date.
This work has not been submitted to any other examination authority either at Blanquerna School of Communication and International Relations or elsewhere.
I am aware that the incorporation of material from other works or the paraphrasing of such material without acknowledgement will be treated by the faculty as academic fraud-plagiarism.
I accept the academic and legal consequences that the violation of this plagiarism declaration may entail

International migration has become a highly debated and politicized topic in modern global affairs, often labeled as a "crisis" in political discussions. Nevertheless, an analysis based on facts reveals a more complex situation. The International Organization for Migration states that around 3. 6% of the global population were international migrants in 2020, a number that, while rising from about 1. 5% in 2000, still appears relatively small. (IOM, 2020). This change indicates broader trends of globalization rather than an extraordinary or overwhelming event. (Haas, Castles and Miller, 2020). The difference between how migration is perceived and its actual situation has led to the development of migration policies focused on security, especially in the Euro-Mediterranean area. Within this scenario, Morocco serves as an important case, having transformed from a country where people leave to a significant transit and increasingly a destination point, while playing a crucial role in European migration management, particularly in routes leading to Spain. This essay explores the question of how can governments maintain effective and fair migration management in the face of growing arrivals without resorting to security-focused policies? We will claim that the governance of migration in Morocco is influenced by European-led strategies aimed at security and externalization, which depict movement as a danger and shift the responsibility of border management to Moroccan officials. These trends ultimately compromise both human rights and the efficient management of migration. This essay argues that migration governance in Morocco is increasingly shaped by European securitisation and externalisation strategies, which frame migration as a security threat and shift border management responsibilities onto Moroccan authorities, thereby undermining both migrants' rights and effective long-term governance.

I. Migration Trends and Structural Context of Migration globally and in Morocco

International migration should be seen as a key part of globalization instead of a rare or short-lived issue. As noted by Haas, Castles, and Miller (2020), migration is influenced by lasting structural elements like global inequality, labor market needs, population imbalances, and political unrest. From this viewpoint, migration is not a failure within the international system but a regular and essential aspect of its operation. On a global scale, migration trends are often misunderstood because of the way total numbers are politically utilized. Although the overall number of migrants worldwide has grown over the years, their percentage compared to the total global population has stayed fairly steady. Understanding the difference between absolute numbers and relative percentages is important, as political and media stories often blow the migration figures out of proportion, helping to create a so-called "migration crisis. " In truth, migration patterns are uneven and focused in certain areas and routes, rather than being the same everywhere. In Morocco, the patterns of migration reflect larger structural changes related to regional and global inequalities. Traditionally a nation of emigration, Morocco has become more of a transit country and, more recently, a destination for migrants, especially from Sub-Saharan Africa. Its strategic location connecting Africa and Europe places it in the middle of the Western Mediterranean migration route, particularly toward Spain. This advantageous position has strengthened Morocco's role in wider Euro-Mediterranean migration management frameworks. This change is also evident in policy updates. The regularization program in 2014, which provided legal status to around 25,000 migrants, signified a significant shift towards a more welcoming approach to migration governance (IOM, 2024). However, this initial openness was followed by stricter migration control policies after 2018, showing the variable and politically charged nature of migration management in Morocco. These changes also highlight the effects of outside pressures, especially from European entities, along with domestic political and security factors. In summary, these trends illustrate that migration movements are neither random nor unmanageable, but rather organized and ongoing. These dynamics are further illustrated by data on Assisted Voluntary Return and Reintegration (AVRR) programmes, which highlight the role of transit countries in

migration systems. In 2018, countries such as Niger and Morocco were among the main host or transit countries for migrants benefiting from return programmes, while countries of origin were primarily located in Sub-Saharan Africa and conflict-affected regions such as Iraq and Afghanistan (IOM, 2020). This distribution confirms that migration flows are structured along specific regional corridors and reinforces Morocco's role as a key transit space within the Euro-Mediterranean migration system. This highlights the necessity for enduring governance strategies based on a structural comprehension of migration trends, rather than reactive policies influenced by perceived crises. In the case of Morocco, this structural reality also lays the groundwork for understanding how securitization and externalization processes influence migration governance.

II. Securitization of Migration trends in Morocco

In order to understand and make a plausible recommendation of Morocco's policy on migration, we need to understand one of the most relevant in nowadays framework study of migration, which is the securitization framework. Our policy recommendation will not follow this trend, but it is part of our environment of study. Based on the work of Buzan, Wæver and de Wilde in 1998, securitisation happens when political figures present an issue as a serious threat, which makes it acceptable to take unusual steps that are not part of regular democratic or policy processes. Regarding migration, this approach changes movement from a social or economic issue into a security matter that needs immediate regulation and limitation.

In Morocco, the process of securitisation is heavily impacted by wider European narratives and policy goals. Specifically, irregular migration toward Europe is increasingly described as a security issue connected to border management, instability, and managing risks. This way of presenting migration supports the justification for strict migration policies and strengthens the idea that migration is a danger instead of just a structural issue. Securitisation also means that exceptional measures can be justified, which are outside the usual political and administrative processes, enabling governments to implement strict migration controls, as noted by Buzan and his colleagues in 1998. In Morocco, this is evident through the enhanced management of borders and surveillance systems aimed at regulating movement, especially concerning the route across the Western Mediterranean toward Spain. This process of viewing migration as a security issue is supported by the collaboration and practices of institutions in both Morocco and the European Union. The management of migration is increasingly influenced by shared border control systems, where Moroccan officials are key in managing irregular migrations. Consequently, migration is integrated into a larger security framework that encompasses both Europe and the Mediterranean region.

This phenomenon can also be explained by Jef Huysmans's point that securitisation often functions through bureaucratic and technical means rather than outright political discussions. In this context, migration in Morocco is often seen as an administrative and technical matter, rather than a political or social issue. Routine actions like border inspections, monitoring, and the classification of migrants make it common to view migration as a security matter. This supports Huysmans's notion that security is shaped by daily administrative practices, where migration becomes something that is controlled instead of discussed politically. Thus, migration is increasingly seen as a technical matter dealt with by security and administrative bodies rather than a political subject.

Looking at the facts, these trends can be seen in migration statistics and policy changes. Estimates indicate that roughly 100,000 migrants are living in Morocco, though numbers can differ based on sources like the International Organization for Migration. The regularisation effort in 2014 led to

about 25,000 migrants receiving legal status, showing a selective change in an otherwise restrictive environment. At the same time, there has been a rise in irregular crossings through the Western Mediterranean route to Spain, especially after 2017, indicating that migration flows continue despite the security-focused governance.

In summary, the securitisation of migration in Morocco illustrates both local institutional practices and outside pressures, particularly from European migration governance. It leads to viewing migration as an ongoing security challenge and strengthens the notion of mobility as a technical and administrative subject, rather than a wider social and political issue. From a policy perspective, this implies that Moroccan authorities should move beyond reactive border control and instead integrate migration into long-term governance planning.

III. EXTERNALIZATION OF MIGRATION : MOROCCO AS A KEY ACTOR

Alongside the process of securitisation, migration governance in Morocco is significantly shaped by dynamics of externalisation. Externalisation refers to the strategy through which destination countries, particularly those of the European Union, shift the management of migration flows beyond their own territory by delegating responsibilities to neighbouring or transit countries (Menjívar, 2014). Through this approach, migration is managed upstream, before it reaches European territory, effectively extending border control beyond EU borders.

In this context, Morocco occupies a central position within the Euro-Mediterranean migration system. Due to its geographical proximity to Europe, particularly Spain, it has become a key partner in managing migration routes across the Western Mediterranean. Consequently, Moroccan authorities are increasingly involved in controlling irregular migration flows directed towards Europe, reinforcing their role within a broader system of transnational migration governance. As shown by Collyer (2007), migration trajectories through Morocco are rarely linear, but rather characterised by prolonged stays, changing routes, and constrained mobility. This highlights how Morocco functions not only as a passage point but also as a space where migration is effectively contained and managed before reaching Europe.

This dynamic is institutionalised through various forms of cooperation between Morocco and the European Union, including financial support, technical assistance, and joint border management initiatives. These arrangements aim to strengthen Morocco’s capacity to control migration flows while aligning its policies with European priorities. As highlighted by Lavenex and Schimmelfennig (2009), this reflects a form of “external governance”, whereby European rules and policy frameworks are projected beyond EU territory.

From a governance perspective, these dynamics raise several critical issues that must be taken into account. The externalisation of migration control generates a structural imbalance, as Morocco assumes increasing responsibilities in border management without necessarily benefiting from equivalent political leverage or guarantees regarding the protection of migrants’ rights. This asymmetry may create tensions between security objectives and the need to ensure fair and humane migration governance. Moreover, externalisation contributes to the geographical displacement of borders, meaning that migration control effectively begins outside European territory. This places additional pressure on Moroccan institutions, which must simultaneously address domestic migration challenges and external expectations. Such a dual role complicates the development of coherent and autonomous migration policies.

Overall, externalisation should not be understood merely as a technical arrangement, but as a political process that reshapes governance priorities. For policymakers, it highlights the need to carefully balance international cooperation with national policy autonomy, while ensuring that migration governance is not reduced solely to external security imperatives. Although partenariat in migration policies with the European Union enhances control abilities, it can also lead to imbalances and may restrict the freedom of national policies. This indicates that successful migration management needs to find a middle ground between global collaboration and safeguarding the rights of migrants while ensuring consistent national policies.

IV. Limits of current migration policy system :

Present migration management in Morocco, influenced by security and external pressures, reveals significant structural challenges. Although these methods seek to regulate migration patterns, they do not tackle the root causes and could lead to negative outcomes.
To start, security measures do not lessen migration numbers; instead, they alter the pathways taken. Since migration is fueled by basic factors, strict regulations often push people towards riskier and irregular routes, elevating the dangers faced by migrants without truly restricting their movement. Additionally, the practice of externalisation creates a noticeable gap in the distribution of responsibilities. By allowing Morocco to manage border enforcement, the European Union lowers the number of arrivals but transfers the political and operational difficulties to a transit nation. This imbalance limits Morocco's freedom in forming policies and makes it harder to create cohesive migration plans, even with attempts to enhance governance capabilities. Real data from the IOM highlight this strain: in 2024, more than 36,000 migrants and vulnerable individuals from Morocco received help (+9% compared to 2023), while 2,712 Moroccans stuck overseas returned home voluntarily, and 8,592 people, including many unaccompanied minors, sought medical care.
Lastly, both security and externalisation approaches may weaken rights-focused strategies by presenting migration mainly as a security challenge. This contradicts global agreements like the United Nations (2016) New York Declaration for Refugees and Migrants, which highlights the importance of safeguarding migrants' rights and the necessity for compassionate and cooperative governance. Reducing migration to merely a matter of control fails to recognize its wider social, economic, and humanitarian impacts.
In conclusion, these challenges indicate that existing methods are not just inadequate but could also be counterproductive, reinforcing the urgent need for a more equitable and informed approach to migration governance.

V. Policy recommendations :

In light of the structural limits identified in current migration governance, exposed in the firsts parts of our paper analysis, several priorities should guide policy action in Morocco. We chose to identify five policy recommendations that would really benefit governance of migration flows in the country.

- First, Moroccan authorities should move beyond a predominantly securitised approach to migration. While border control remains necessary, excessive reliance on security measures has proven ineffective in reducing migration flows and has contributed to the development of more irregular and dangerous routes. Migration should instead be recognised as a structural and long-term phenomenon and integrated into broader national policy frameworks. Cooperation in migration flows is therefore a key point.

- Second, the government is urged to enhance the legal and organizational routes for migration. By creating regulated labor migration options and improving the processes for legalizing migrants, authorities can lessen irregular migration and increase their ability to oversee movement. Additionally, providing access to basic services like healthcare, education, and job opportunities is crucial to lowering migrants' risks and fostering community harmony.
- Third, the way migration is managed should be firmly based on rights. This means bolstering protection systems for at-risk groups, especially unaccompanied minors, and making sure that national strategies align with global commitments, including the New York Declaration of 2016 and the Global Compact for Migration from 2018.
- Fourth, Morocco ought to adjust its collaboration with the European Union. While these partnerships are important, the current arrangements lead to imbalances in sharing responsibilities. Therefore, Moroccan officials should aim for fairer cooperation agreements, which include more financial aid, legal migration paths, and shared responsibilities for protection.

Lastly, migration strategies should tackle the main causes of migration. This involves enhancing partnerships with home countries, why not fostering a regional and MENA migration policy, in transregional forums, and incorporating migration into larger plans that focus on development, job creation, and addressing inequality and not seeing it as a mainly security focus. Overall, effective migration governance in Morocco requires a shift towards a more balanced, comprehensive, and maybe the most important aspect, a long-term approach that combines control, protection, and structural policy responses.

BIBLIOGRAPHY :

Bello, V. (2017) *International Migration and International Security*. United Nations interview, 21 April. Available at: http://www.un.org [Accessed: April 18th 2026].

Bello, V. (2022) 'The spiralling of the securitisation of migration in the EU: from the management of a "crisis" to a governance of human mobility?', *Journal of Ethnic and Migration Studies*, 48(6), pp. 1327–1344.

Buzan, B., Wæver, O. and de Wilde, J. (1998) *Security: A New Framework for Analysis*. Boulder, CO: Lynne Rienner Publishers.

Bigo, D. (2002) 'Security and Immigration: Toward a Critique of the Governmentality of Unease', *Alternatives: Global, Local, Political*, 27(s1), pp. 63–92.

Collyer, M. (2007) 'In-between places: trans-Saharan transit migrants in Morocco and the fragmented journey to Europe', *Antipode*, 39(4), pp. 668–690.

El Qadim, N. (2018) 'The symbolic meaning of international mobility: EU-Morocco negotiations on visa facilitation', *Migration Studies*, 6(2), pp. 279–305.

Haas, H. de, Castles, S. and Miller, M.J. (2020) *The Age of Migration: International Population Movements in the Modern World*. 6th edn. London: Red Globe Press.

Huysmans, J. (2006) *The Politics of Insecurity: Fear, Migration and Asylum in the EU*. London: Routledge.

International Organization for Migration (IOM) (2020) *World Migration Report 2020*. Geneva: IOM.

International Organization for Migration (IOM) (2024) *Migration in Morocco: Snapshot*. Available at: https://morocco.iom.int (Accessed: [May 1st 2026]).

Menjívar, C. (2014) 'Immigration Law Beyond Borders: Externalizing and Internalizing Border Controls in an Era of Securitization', *Annual Review of Law and Social Science*, 10, pp. 353–369.

Reifeld, H. (2015) 'Emigration, Transit and Host Country: Migration in Morocco', *KAS International Reports*, 2–3, pp. 95–115.

Reuveny, R. (2007) 'Climate change-induced migration and violent conflict', *Political Geography*, 26(6), pp. 656–673.

United Nations (2018) *Global Compact for Safe, Orderly and Regular Migration*. New York: United Nations.

Lavenex, S. and Schimmelfennig, F. (2009) 'EU rules beyond EU borders: theorizing external governance in European politics', *Journal of European Public Policy*, 16(6), pp. 791–812.

Weiner, M. (1985) 'On International Migration and International Relations', *Population and Development Review*, 11(3), pp. 441–455